

EXECUTION EXCELLENCE WITH OKRs — Quick Reference Cheat Sheet

The 90-Day Blueprint for Managers | All frameworks, formulas & scripts in one place

THE OKR FORMULA

OBJECTIVE

What you want to achieve — qualitative, inspiring, action-oriented, clear

KEY RESULTS

[Metric] from [Baseline] to [Target]

FORMULA:[Action Verb] + [What You're Improving] + [For Whom]

4 QUALITIES OF GREAT OBJECTIVES

Qualitative	No numbers in objectives — numbers belong only in Key Results
Inspiring	Worth fighting for — creates energy, not obligation
Clear	Same interpretation for every person who reads it
Action-Oriented	Use: Build, Win, Create, Transform Avoid: Improve, Maintain

5 QUALITIES OF GREAT KEY RESULTS

Measurable	Has a specific number with a clear target
Outcome-Focused	Results, not activities or tasks — what changed?
Baseline + Target	Both numbers required — no baseline = no KR
Single Owner	One person accountable. Shared ownership = no ownership
Stretchy (0.7)	Ambitious but achievable — 70% confidence to hit it

SCORING SCALE — Target is 0.7, not 1.0

0.0	No progress — something went fundamentally wrong
0.3	Some progress — significant miss on expectations
0.5	Significant progress — meaningful but short of goal
0.7 ★	TARGET — Strong performance, met expectations
0.8–0.9	Excellent execution — or was the target too easy?
1.0	Exceeded — exceptional, or target was sandbagged

THE BEHAVIOR TEST

"If this KR exists, how will people behave differently?"

If gaming the metric creates bad outcomes — you have the wrong metric.

THE 90-DAY STRUCTURE

FOUNDATION

Days 1–14 | Understand OKRs, outcomes & strategy

CRAFT

Days 15–30 | Write objectives, key results & align teams

LAUNCH

Days 31–45 | Build rhythm, run check-ins & get buy-in

EXECUTION

Days 46–75 | Run reviews, course-correct & keep momentum

COMPLETION

Days 76–90 | Score results, run retro & draft next cycle

THE OKR RHYTHM — 5 Recurring Rituals

Freq	Activity	Duration	Who
Weekly	Individual Check-In	15 min	Each person
Weekly	Team 3P Review	30 min	Manager + Team
Monthly	All-Hands Update	60 min	Full Dept/Company
Week 5–6	Mid-Cycle Deep Review	2–3 hrs	Leadership
Week 10–11	End-Cycle Retro & Score	2–3 hrs	Leadership + Teams

THE 5 CHECK-IN ELEMENTS — 15 min, Weekly, Non-negotiable

VALUE	What's the current number? Facts over feelings — not effort, not narrative
CONFIDENCE	1–10: How likely to hit the target? Early warning system — drops before results drop
COMMENTS	What context is important? (< 50 words) Qualitative insight — story behind the number
FOCUS	What's the priority for next week? One specific priority — not a to-do list
BLOCKERS	What help is needed? Surface obstacles — makes asking for help safe

CONFIDENCE SIGNAL PATTERNS — 2+ point drop = immediate action

Steady 8–9	On track — keep monitoring
Drops 2+ points	New info / reality shift — investigate
Low → High	Corrections working — keep it up
Stuck at 7	Hiding reality — challenge the honesty
Wildly fluctuating	Poor measurement — improve tracking

THE "SO WHAT?" CHAIN — Trace any activity to business impact

Activity → Output → So what? → So what? → OUTCOME (measure this)
The final answer in the chain is what you should actually be measuring.

8 REASONS OKR IMPLEMENTATIONS FAIL

- Set & Forget**
No weekly check-ins. OKRs are an operating system, not a planning exercise.
- OKRs = To-Do Lists**
Tasks are not KRs. 'Send 50 emails' is a task. '20 qualified leads' is a KR.
- Too Many OKRs**
1 Objective, 3–5 KRs MAX per quarter. If everything is a priority, nothing is.
- Unhandled Resistance**
Address skeptics in Days 1–14, not Day 45. Resistance starts on Day 1.
- No Baseline Data**
No baseline = no KR. Find the real number first — no estimates allowed.
- No Strategy Link**
If you can't connect your KR to company priority in 2 steps, you're not aligned.
- Changing OKRs Monthly**
Constant change = no OKRs. Commit fully for 90 days. Hard ≠ wrong.
- No Leadership Visible**
If the CEO skips check-ins, everyone else will too. Leadership goes first.

THE 3P MEETING FRAMEWORK — 30 min, Every Week

PROGRESS

10 min — What moved?

Numbers only. 30 seconds per person. No stories, no explanations.
Rule: If update takes > 30 seconds, you're doing it wrong.

PLAN

10 min — What will move?

Each person states ONE specific focus for the week, connected to a KR.
Rule: Not 'work on X' — state the specific action and expected impact.

PROBLEM

10 min — What's stuck?

Real blockers only. Every problem raised must have an owner and deadline.
Rule: Thank people for surfacing blockers — never ask 'why didn't you fix it?'

SKEPTIC RESPONSE MATRIX — Validate before you redirect

"Just another fad"	"You're right to be skeptical. Let's run one 90-day cycle and evaluate with data."
"We have no time"	"OKRs clarify priorities and cut wasted effort. If they add work, we'll adjust."
"Work can't be measured"	"What would success look like? How would we know it's working? Start there."
"Leadership won't follow"	"I'm committed for 90 days. Judge me by my consistency — call me out if I slip."
"This is micromanagement"	"You set the targets. You own the how. Check-ins exist to get you help, not judge you."

COURSE CORRECTION — Trigger: Confidence drops below 6

CHANGE APPROACH	Most common
Approach isn't working. Keep target, change method.	
ADD RESOURCES	Sometimes
Right approach, under-resourced. Confirm approach first.	
ADJUST TARGET	Rare — use carefully
External events changed reality genuinely.	
ABANDON KR	Very rare
KR itself was wrong — achieving it would cause harm.	

LEADING vs. LAGGING INDICATORS

Function	Leading (Windshield — predict)	Lagging (Rearview — confirm)
Sales	Pipeline created this week	Revenue closed
Marketing	MQLs generated	Customers acquired
Product	Beta user engagement	Feature adoption rate
CS	Health score trends	Churn rate
Eng	Incident response time	System uptime %

Review leading indicators weekly. Review lagging indicators monthly.

WEEK-BY-WEEK EXECUTION FOCUS

DAYS 1-3

FOUNDATION

- Run Alignment Audit — ask 5 people: 'What's our #1 priority?'
- Run Dashboard Theater Diagnosis on last 3 reports
- Name your top 2-3 skeptics — you need them early

DAYS 4-7

MINDSET SHIFT

- Run Output-to-Outcome Converter for 5 current work items
- Apply 'So What?' chain to top 5 team activities
- Change what you celebrate — outcomes, not outputs

DAYS 8-14

STRATEGY

- Document Vision → Strategy → Annual → OKR cascade
- Use Fibonacci method to prioritize potential objectives
- Identify internal customer — validate alignment with them

DAYS 15-17

OBJECTIVES

- Generate 5 draft objectives — apply 4 qualities test
- Apply Newspaper Test: would this make a great headline?
- Run Objective Stress Test — need 6/8 to proceed

DAYS 18-26

KEY RESULTS

- Brainstorm 10+ metrics per objective before filtering
- Apply Behavior Test to each metric — cut gaming risks
- Hunt real baselines — no estimates, no guessing allowed
- Set 0.7 stretch targets — 70% confidence you'll hit it

DAYS 27-30

ALIGNMENT

- Map dependencies: who do I need? who needs me?
- Run alignment conversations with each key partner
- Validate the math — do conversion rates actually add up?

DAYS 31-35

LAUNCH

- Block ALL five OKR rhythm meetings in calendar TODAY
- Run Meeting Audit — eliminate or replace inefficient ones
- Send team prep instructions 24 hours before first check-in

DAYS 36-45

RHYTHM

- Run first individual check-in using 5-element script
- Run first 3P team review — enforce 30 min strictly
- Hold Skeptic Conversion 1:1s — listen before redirecting

THE KR PYRAMID — Match KR type to your level of control

Executive

80% Outcomes | 20% Outputs

Revenue, NPS, market share, profitability

Department

60% Outcomes | 40% Outputs

Pipeline, adoption rate, CSAT score

Team

50% Outcomes | 50% Outputs

Features adopted, leads converted to SQL

Individual

20% Outcomes | 80% Outputs

Tasks completed, deliverables shipped

RED FLAGS — Stop & Fix Before Moving Forward

More than 20% of KRs are qualitative — you're avoiding accountability

Qualitative KR has no 'as validated by' clause — it's a wish, not a KR

Same qualitative KR appears two cycles in a row — quantify it now

Can't get 30 minutes with your manager — you can't align without access

Team has more than one 'urgent crisis' per week — not ready for OKRs yet

3P meetings regularly exceed 30 minutes — enforce storytelling ban

Problem section is always empty — people are hiding blockers from you

Same blockers appear week after week without resolution — escalate

Confidence stuck at exactly 7 for 3+ consecutive weeks — probe this

KR at 0.2 with 6 weeks remaining and no recovery plan — act now

DASHBOARD THEATER MATRIX

METRIC GREEN

Business Growing

TRUE SUCCESS ✓

Business Declining

DASHBOARD THEATER ✗

METRIC RED

DASHBOARD THEATER ✗

HONEST SIGNAL ✓

OKRs vs. KPIs vs. TASKS — Know the difference

KPIs

Measure ongoing health (like a heart rate monitor)

Tell you WHERE you are — not where to go

Tasks

Describe activity ('send 50 emails', 'launch site')

Keep you busy — don't guarantee outcomes

OKRs

Drive change and improvement toward a clear outcome

Tell you WHERE you need to GO — and if you got there

MANAGER QUICK-START CHECKLIST — Before Day 1

☐ Block 2-3 hours per week for OKR work in your calendar NOW

☐ Identify your 2-3 biggest skeptics by name — you need them early

☐ Choose your tracking tool (a shared spreadsheet is perfectly fine)

☐ Schedule 30-minute conversation with your manager about priorities

☐ Gather existing strategy docs, company goals, and current priorities

☐ Book alignment conversations with key cross-functional dependencies

CHECK-IN CHALLENGE SCRIPTS — Word-for-word responses

"I don't know my confidence"

"Let's project it. At the current trajectory, where will you end up by quarter end?"

"Confidence stuck at 7 every week"

"Based specifically on THIS week — are you more or less confident than last week?"

"KR at 0.2 with 6 weeks left"

"At current trajectory, where do we land? What would need to change dramatically?"

"Everything is fine" (when it's not)

"Help me understand the math. You're at X with Y weeks remaining — walk me through it."

FINAL SCORE FORMULA

Score = (Achieved Value – Baseline)

(Target – Baseline)

Example: Baseline 2, Target 10, Achieved 7 → (7-2)/(10-2) = 0.625

THE STRATEGY CASCADE — OKRs are the 90-day bridge

VISION (5-10 yrs)

Where are we going? (North Star, rarely changes)

STRATEGY (1-3 yrs)

How will we get there? What we'll say no to

ANNUAL (1 year)

What must we prove this year to advance the strategy?

OKRs (90 days)

What will we achieve this quarter to advance annual?

TASKS (Weekly)

What specific work will we do this week?

OBJECTIVE LANGUAGE GUIDE

USE:

Transform Build Create Launch Win Become Capture Achieve

AVOID:

Improve Enhance Maintain Continue Support Try Monitor

THE FOCUS QUESTION — Ask this before every planning session:

"If we could accomplish only ONE THING in the next 90 days, what single outcome would advance our strategy the most?"

OKR MATURITY SCORECARD — Self-assess each cycle (Score /50)

Score Range

Level

Focus for Next Cycle

10 – 20

BEGINNER

Start with rhythm — check-ins above everything else

21 – 35

DEVELOPING

Improve KR quality and build honest reporting culture

36 – 45

PRACTICING

Optimize speed of correction and cross-team alignment

46 – 50

ADVANCED

Teach others — export the practice beyond your team

"The discipline of showing up weekly matters more than any individual check-in." — Sasi Dharan